

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

2014-02-17

To an individual Bahá'í

307 55 17 February 2014 To an individual Bahá'í Dear Bahá'í Friend, 55.1 The House of Justice was sorry to hear of the continuing

difficulties you are experiencing as a devoted member of the community of the Greatest Name and that the clarifications provided in the letter dated 7 November 2010 written to you on its behalf have not assisted in their resolution. It is well aware of the challenges that some of the friends in the United States are facing, which obstruct the progress of expansion and consolidation. These challenges, however, lie not in the provisions of the Plan itself but rather in misunderstandings surrounding those provisions. The House of Justice observes that, occasionally, the discussion concerning the Plan has fallen into a misleading dichotomy: that individuals should engage either in a few narrowly defined activities centered around the training institute or that they should be free to choose any initiative that they wish to undertake without regard for the requirements of the Plan. Wherever this fruitless discussion emerges, in whatever variation, the result is to reduce the enthusiasm and participation of the believers and prevent them from engaging in the process of learning that lies at the heart of the Plan—a process that will, if unitedly and persistently pursued, resolve misconceptions, promote flexibility, and shed light over time on the most effective course of action.

55.2 The House of Justice hopes that you will reflect on how

this type of discussion may be inadvertently influencing your own conceptions about the Plan. For example, you refer to “teaching in very prescribed ways.” However, the guidance concerning the Plan does not prescribe a particular method of teaching, nor is any method of individual teaching proscribed. You ask whether an individual is free to share views on the progress of activities, yet it should be evident that such a 308 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION contribution is fundamental to the learning process, which includes study of the guidance, consultation, action, and re - flection. This, of course, should be carried out in a manner that seeks to understand and effectively implement the provisions of the Plan lest insistence upon personal opinions trap the friends in interminable debate on dichotomous perspectives and inhibit their understanding and action. 55.3 The essence of the series of Plans that have unfolded

since 1996 is relatively simple. Individuals, communities, and institutions are called upon, within the context of a cluster, to create a program of growth involving a vibrant, meaningful, and distinctive pattern of collective Bahá'í life, infused by the spirit of the Creative Word, and open not only to the believers but to those from the wider society. At the core of this community-building process are certain activities—devotional gatherings, the educating of children and junior youth, and the raising up of those who can engage in acts of service—that serve as portals for the participation of ever-increasing numbers. The four core activities are but the nucleus of an organic pattern of life that, as the number of individuals who can initiate activities multiplies, increases in complexity over time, eventually requiring coherence among a range of efforts that also includes visits to homes, social gatherings, Feast

and Holy Day observances, deepenings, administration, strengthening the Fund, social action, involvement in the discourses of society, and so on. All these activities are sustained and expanded by the constant endeavors of individuals to reach out to their personal contacts as well as to receptive populations through direct teaching, both personal and collective, and engagement in meaningful conversations. The process of building growing communities is cultivated within three-monthly cycles of planning and action, and it is supported by institutional arrangements at the local, cluster, regional, national, and international levels. In far-flung regions of the earth, the friends in diverse countries are learning to advance the programs of growth in their clusters, ranging from those with a few simple activities to those involving hundreds of activities with the participation of thousands of individuals in a pattern of life that is spiritual, dynamic, united, growing, and transformative in nature. The House of Justice has no doubt that the American believers—who have, over the course of nearly a century of the unfoldment of the 309

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]